

Chapter 31: The First Interruption

For the first time in months, Austin didn't come.

Jenny noticed at 11:07 a.m.

Not because she was waiting.

At least, that was what she told herself.

She was carrying a tray of dumplings when she glanced toward the front of the restaurant and realized table seven was empty.

Still empty.

The seat remained untouched.

No coffee.

No jacket hanging on the chair.

No familiar figure pretending not to watch her.

Nothing.

Jenny looked away immediately.

It shouldn't matter.

People had lives.

People missed days.

People got busy.

Austin especially.

But as lunch service continued, she found herself checking anyway.

Once.

Then twice.

Then far more than she wanted to admit.

By two in the afternoon, irritation had replaced curiosity.

By four, irritation had become something else.

Something she refused to name.

"You're looking at the door."

Jenny nearly dropped the glass she was holding.

"I am not."

Bao didn't even bother hiding his grin.

"You absolutely are."

"I'm working."

"You checked the entrance six times in the last ten minutes."

Jenny placed the glass down harder than necessary.

"Maybe I'm waiting for customers."

"Sure."

Bao nodded dramatically.

"The customer."

Jenny pointed a finger at him.

"Go do your job."

"I am doing my job."

"No."

He laughed.

"This is much more interesting."

Jenny grabbed a towel and threw it at him.

Bao caught it easily.

Unfortunately.

At five thirty, her phone buzzed.

A message.

For a split second, her heart reacted before her brain did.

She hated that.

Hated it immediately.

When she checked the screen, she found only a message from her mother.

Not Austin.

Jenny frowned at herself.

Ridiculous.

Completely ridiculous.

That evening, after her shift ended, she called home.

The familiar voice of her mother filled the line.

"Jenny."

A smile appeared instantly.

"Hi, Ma."

The conversation was normal.

Questions about health.

Weather.

Bills.

The small repairs needed on the family house.

The price of rice.

The usual concerns of people trying to survive.

Jenny listened carefully.

As always.

She was the one who sent money.

The one who helped.

The one who carried responsibility.

She had been doing it for years.

And she would continue doing it.

Because no one else was going to.

Toward the end of the call, her mother asked softly,

"Are you eating properly?"

Jenny smiled.

"Yes."

"Liar."

That made her laugh.

"How do you always know?"

"A mother knows."

The laughter faded.

Warmth remained.

Then her mother added something unexpected.

"You sound happier these days."

Jenny froze.

Only for a second.

But it was enough.

"Happier?"

"Yes."

A pause.

"Did someone enter your life?"

Jenny looked out the apartment window.

The city lights shimmered in the distance.

Immediately, a certain man appeared in her mind.

Tall.

Controlled.

Annoyingly persistent.

She pushed the thought away.

"No."

Her mother hummed.

A sound that clearly meant she didn't believe her.

"Okay."

"Ma."

"I'm not saying anything."

"You are."

Another laugh came through the phone.

Jenny smiled despite herself.

The next day, Austin still didn't appear.

That was unusual.

Very unusual.

Jenny didn't realize how unusual until the afternoon.

Until she caught herself feeling disappointed.

That realization annoyed her instantly.

She was a grown woman.

Not a teenager waiting for messages.

Not someone whose day depended on another person.

And yet—

The restaurant felt different.

Again.

Too quiet.

Too ordinary.

Near closing time, the bell above the door finally rang.

Jenny looked up automatically.

And froze.

Austin stood inside.

But he wasn't alone.

A woman entered behind him.

Tall.

Elegant.

Expensive-looking.

Everything about her radiated confidence.

She wore a fitted black coat and carried herself like someone used to being listened to.

Austin looked tired.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

Which was somehow more alarming.

Their eyes met immediately.

For one brief moment, something flickered across his face.

Relief.

Then it disappeared.

The woman beside him glanced around the restaurant.

Her gaze eventually landed on Jenny.

Sharp.

Assessing.

Interested.

Jenny felt her stomach tighten.

Not from jealousy.

Not yet.

From instinct.

Something had changed.

And whatever Austin had been dealing with for the last two days...

Had just walked into the restaurant beside him.

The woman smiled politely.

Then turned to Austin.

"Is this the place?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

His eyes remained on Jenny.

For one second longer than necessary.

Then he quietly said,

"Yes."

And for the first time since meeting him...

Jenny felt the outside world pushing its way into theirs.

End of Chapter 31 ❤️